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Copenhagen Calling - Denmark Has A Thriving Start-up Scene To Rival Its World-Beating Business Culture

Edmund Ingham
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Danes have a fantastic reputation as businesspeople; the country regularly tops surveys and lists of the best places in the world for work culture and work / life balance, even prompting Presidential candidate and Senator Bernie Sanders to ask "why can't we be more like Denmark?" leading Hilary Clinton to exclaim in reply "I love Denmark!"

Sanders' view of Denmark as a Socialist utopia and Clinton's objection that Denmark is too small to be comparable to the States is only a small part of the Danish story however – it's true that Denmark has some of the highest taxes in the world which support an egalitarian and generally flat hierarchical structure within most work places and keeps employment figures close to 100%.

In Denmark it's hard to slip outside of the system but although many would argue high taxation and conformity are anathema to entrepreneurs, its capital Copenhagen is becoming as open and receptive to new ways of thinking as it has ever been.

The city in which Kierkegaard lived and attended University is renowned for its protestant values but is above all else tolerant and a breeding ground for new ideas, which has allowed a thriving start-up scene to spring up over the past decade, attracting international talent and disrupting entire industries, both at home and abroad, and particularly in the fields of search and discover and workforce management -it's influence often spreading to the States to an extent that might surprise Hilary.

Taylor Ryan, who was born and grew up in Washington DC, is an American who has experienced the explosion of Danish startup culture first hand after joining Planday, a shift scheduling and workplace management solution that was first launched in 2004 by current CTO Mikkel Lomholt who was working shifts at a nightclub at the time. Frustrated by employee no-shows, issues with payroll and the rigid nature of the working hours, he decided to build a tool that could handle the entire organisational side of a business' staffing requirements.

In January 2005 Anders Frederikson joined as Sales Director and as the business grew and grew, Cristian Broendum joined as CEO and investor in 2011.

The business won 3 of Danish daily business newspaper Borsen's coveted Gazelle awards in recognition of its being amongst Denmark's fastest growing businesses and won investment from Creandum, a Danish VC firm, in May 2014, before completing a Series B funding round raise of $14 million, backed by Just Eat founder Klaus Nyengaard, Creandum, SEB Private Equity and Angel investor Arthur Kosten, just a few weeks ago.

Taylor joined Planday a few months before the completion of the Series B; "now we're the talk of the town", he told me. The company has offices in Islands Brygge, near the City centre, an area often referred to as "Startup Village" and home to a large number of early stage startups, all hoping to replicate the success of Planday. It's a competitive environment and ensures that high standards have to be maintained if companies are to succeed, which in turn helps cement Denmark's growing reputation as a startup hub.

"Planday took a business idea – improving workforce management and making it more agile, responsive and flexible – that nobody out there could get right. Planday built a system that can cope with the changing needs of the workforce and we're betting that the market is going to love it.", says Taylor.

"The great thing about Planday is that it's a system that suits millennials down to the ground and millennials are going to form the bulk of the workforce and control the workplace for the foreseeable future", Taylor says; "many young people work 2 or 3 jobs, and they expect to be able to have the tools to juggle projects around, move shifts, swap shifts, bid for lucrative shifts, and know when and how much they are getting paid. They expect this as a minimum requirement and Planday is one of the few services that matches their expectations across the board."

"Likewise, employers want to pinch every penny, they don't want to lose revenues thanks to no-shows, or because staff are de-motivated because they don't feel supported."

Although he spent nearly a decade working the start-up scene in DC, Taylor regards himself as lucky to have found a job at such a high-growth startup so quickly in Copenhagen. "I saw the opportunity and jumped on it", he says. "The growth is extraordinary – for example, Planday has doubled their staff numbers over the past year."

The "supercool" (he is adjusting to European startup lingo well) startup friendly offices spread out over 3 spacious floors "have their own kind of magic, it feels like we're working on something really special here" he says; "people here really dig what they do."

A criticism often levelled at flat business structures is that staff lack motivation, preferring to work shorter hours and prioritising life away from the office, but Taylor says he sees none of that happening in Copenhagen. "It's not true what they say that people here work shorter hours – people are putting blood, sweat and tears into these projects – I've never seen people leave early, or even look like they might want to – people are desperate to succeed and prepared to do whatever it takes" he says.

There are plenty of after-hours events, usually "filled to the gills, you're lucky to get a seat in the venues at all" and mentoring schemes; "it's crazy, everyone wants everyone to succeed!"

And that is what is happening – Denmark is a small country which means international expansion happens early – Planday has recently opened an office in New York, and it is generally de rigeur for ambitious Copenhagen startups to have a presence in Sweden, London, Spain, Italy and France.

"There has definitely been an influx of funding over the last few years and the scene here is exciting – it's a ride I'm happy to be on – I don't know where it will end but I'm just happy to be on it", says Taylor.

One of his favourite aspects of working life are the group lunches where "you can end up sitting and talking to almost anybody from the company – everybody is approachable, from the CEO to the newest intern – it opens up communication channels and makes everything seem friendlier, but it also means new ideas are picked up and integrated quicker."

Planday and many other companies in Copenhagen, like Peter Muhlmann's TrustPilot, which has raised in the hundreds of millions, a lot of it from New York based investors, are blazing a trail. Food for thought, Hilary?

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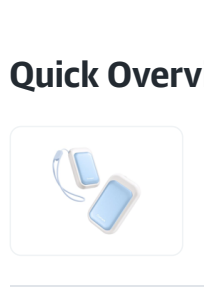
Dyson

The festive lights, time off and cute scarfs can only conceal the truth for so long: Winter can be pretty bleak. I don't mean to be a downer, but it's cold all of the time, dark most of the time and this lasts far beyond the most wonderful time of the year. Here at Engadget, we've tried so many tools and products to make winter more bearable from therapy lamps to heaters. We've invested in tea sets, wrapped ourselves in heated blankets and learned to grow herbs indoors — really, anything that will make these three-plus months more bearable, we've tried.

Here, you'll find some of the best winter tech getting us at Engadget through the coldest months, plus a number of recommendations from our other gift guides that will get anyone through the winter warm, comfortable and content.

Quick Overview



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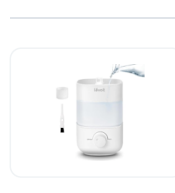

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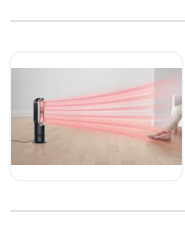

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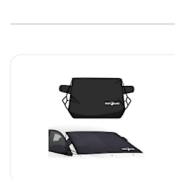

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Best winter tech and gear

OCOOPA

OCOOPA UT4 Young Rechargeable Magnetic Hand Warmers (2 Pack)

A gift anyone can appreciate is the gift of warmth, and a pair of these magnetic hand warmers is one of the cutest (and most convenient) ways to give that. They're rechargeable little pucks that can be used stuck together or separately to warm up frozen hands during the winter — or really, any time of the year. They heat up super fast (truly, within seconds) and will last up to eight hours each on a single charge. They'll even be great for those who insist they never get cold because they're so small and compact that they can use them stealthily in their coat pockets, with no one the wiser. — *Valentina Palladino, Deputy Editor*

$17 at Amazon

Levoit

Levoit Top Fill Humidifier 2.5L

Winter really brings out all the classic, nerdy vibes in me. There's the fact that I am always bundled in a heated blanket reading with my big glasses. There's the need to ensure I always take my inhaler and nasal spray to combat the cold, dry air. Then, there's my trusty companion, the 2.5L Levoit Top Fill humidifier.

My home is always dry and it gets painfully worse anytime the heat goes on (shocking, right?) I typically fill up my Levoit humidifier most of the way before I get into bed and then leave it on overnight. A dial allows me to control how intense the cool mist is that comes out — I typically go for just under half power and position it a couple feet away from me. It has an auto shut-off function, but it can run up to 25 hours so it's normally still on when I wake up. I also like that this humidifier has no disruptive light and is quiet. Though, it's worth saying that I like white noise, while my partner finds its noise a bit disruptive.

There are two really annoying things about humidifiers: putting them together after filling, and cleaning them. This humidifier's design improves both of these things. For starters, the top-fill mechanism means I don't have to flip the whole thing over onto the stand just right in order to use it. I can just hold the container upright and guide it into place. Cleaning is always going to be slightly frustrating, especially since you have to do it after almost every use. But, I've found this model's open design makes it a bit easier and the small brush included means I don't need to waste cotton buds to reach its little nooks. — *Sarah Fielding, Contributing Reporter*

$28 at Amazon

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Dyson

Dyson Hot+Cool Jet Focus fan heater AM09

Every home I've lived in as an adult gets chilly in the winter, and while I default to living underneath piles of blankets, I still wouldn't be able to get through a snowy season without my trusty Dyson AM09 Hot + Cool fan. I've had this thing for over five years at this point and I think it's been in Dyson's lineup for even longer than that — and for good reason. It's an excellent heater in the winter, and it works as a basic fan in the warmer months. It has a few different levels of heat strength, and the Diffused and Jet Focus modes make it easy to heat an entire (small- to medium-sized) room or just the couch my husband and I are sitting on, respectively.

The portion of the machine that pumps out the air can be tilted up and down depending on where you want to direct its focus, and there's an oscillation mode that can keep it turning from side to side. And of course, since it's a Dyson, it's bladeless and pretty sleek looking. It's also lightweight enough to whichever room in the house we need it the most, be it upstairs in the bedroom or all the way downstairs in our basement. Combine that with its handy remote that magnetically attaches to the top of the machine and you have an all-year-round staple that gets just as much use in the winter as it does in the summer. – *V.P.*

$500 at Dyson

FrostGuard

FrostGuard Deluxe Full-Coverage Car Windshield Cover

While this might not directly keep you warm during the coldest months, it will help do so by reducing the amount of time you have to spend outside cleaning the snow and ice off your car. I've had one of these FrostGuard windshield protectors for years, and the hardest part of using it is remembering to cover my car with it ahead of a snowy blast. The latest model comes in two sizes, so you can pick the right one for the car you have, and it fully covers the windshield, wipers and side mirrors, protecting them from snow and ice. Instead of hacking away at a sheet of ice or laboriously sweeping the snow off your vehicle, you just have to remove the FrostGuard to reveal clean and clear surfaces. — *V.P.*

$27 at Amazon

Ember

Ember Temperature Control Smart Mug 2

You'll want to have a warm drink on hand all the time during the winter, and the Ember Mug 2 can make that easier. It offers up to 80 minutes of heat retention at the temperature you set, or all-day warmth when it's sat on its charging plate. It has sensors that detect when warm liquids are poured into it to turn it on, and the built-in indicator light will let you know when the mug has reached your desired temperature. If you're constantly topping up your coffee or tea because it's gone cold on you, this is the next mug you should get. — *V.P.*

$129 at Target

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$129 at Walmart

$90 at Best Buy

OXO

OXO Brew Adjustable Temperature Kettle

OXO's spin on the electric kettle is a reminder of why their products tend to be great — it's attractive, extremely practical and easy to use for those of all technical capabilities. While there are tons of cheap electric kettles on the market, and some that even copy OXO's gorgeous glass styling, the company's version elevates the simple act of boiling water. The glass and stainless steel kettle elevates the look of any kitchen, and its slim base makes it easy to adjust the boiling temperature for different types of tea. It also sports a built-in metal filter to make your pours cleaner, as well as a non-slip handle to help avoid any painful accidents. — *Devindra Hardawar, Senior Reporter*

$117 at Amazon

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$120 at Walmart

Will Lipman Photography for Engadget

Miir New Standard Carafe

Miir's New Standard Carafe is a super-charged Chemex. You get the benefits of a conical pour-over extraction, but the precious brew sits in a double-wall, vacuum insulated stainless steel vessel instead of a glass container. The carafe also comes with a lid that completely closes the spout to keep heat in. This is an easy way to upgrade your pour-over setup and ensure you have warm coffee all season long. — *Billy Steele, Deputy Editor*

$90 at Miir

Bombas

Bombas Men's Merino Wool Blend Calf Sock 4-Pack

Despite climate change, it can still be quite frigid in the northeast US. Times like these are much easier to tolerate with a good pair of socks, and fortunately I found my absolute favorites a few years ago. The Bombas Merino Wool Blend Calf Sock (though you can get any length you please) manages to be extremely warm without being overly thick and bulky, so shoes still fit as you'd expect.

They're not cheap, but there's definitely something to be said for finding a go-to sock for the winter. I don't wear them every day, but whenever temperatures dip below freezing, I pull them out. I'm even excited to get some as a holiday gift, which the kid version of me would be ashamed of. But hey, maybe if I had socks this nice when I was 10, I would have been more excited by them at Christmas. — *Nathan Ingraham, Deputy Editor*

$88 at Bombas

Nekteck

Nekteck Shiatsu Foot Massager Machine with Soothing Heat

Cold feet? No problem. Instead of simply pulling on a pair of fuzzy socks, give your soles a treat by sticking them into a warm foot massager. Now, I'm a bit of a massage snob myself, and generally find massage chairs, belts and neckbands to be too weak or stiff to be comfortable. But when your entire foot is encased by machinery that can use air and rollers to squeeze and knead all your pressure points, it does feel close enough to an actual massage from human hands.

Not only does the simple act of placing your feet in the fabric-lined holes of a box already help warm up your toes, but the stimulation of all the robotic balls and mechanic squeezing results in blood flow that will get you nice and toasty. Throw in the fact that the Nekteck Shiatsu foot massager I recently bought has a heated mode, and even the most reptilian of feet will have an easy time thawing after a 10-minute session. I do have to caution that it takes around three to five cycles to figure out the mode and amount of pressure you like, and that my size 8 feet had enough wiggle room that I could tilt them at angles to get better attention on specific parts of my soles (or avoid getting my tender toes pinched). The larger-footed among us might have a harder time enjoying the Nekteck massager, and those who are generally ticklish or have lower pain thresholds may find the machine too strong, even on the lowest setting.

Still, in the week or so that I've owned it, my Nekteck foot massager has strangely become a sight for my sore eyes and feet, and I relish every opportunity to stick my feet in for a quick warm up and hope to see improvements in my general muscle fatigue in time. — *Cherlynn Low, Managing Editor*

$70 at Amazon

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$90 at Best Buy

Hatch Baby

Hatch Restore 3 Sunrise Alarm Clock

My alarm is set for 6AM three days a week in the ambitious hope that I'll make it to a 6:30AM yoga class. In the winter, it is midnight-dark at that hour and the only reason I occasionally find myself doing an early morning vinyasa is the sunrise alarm clock feature in the Hatch Restore 3. I schedule mine to start filling the room with a gradually brightening glow about 20 minutes before the sounds of singing bowls start playing. The light helps my brain wake up before I do and the subtle bongs of the bowl sort of seep into my subconscious — I often find myself awake almost without knowing why.

True, there are lots of sunrise alarm clocks out there. Many are cheaper and don't have an optional subscription tie-in. But I like the Hatch app, which lets you adjust the duration, colors, brightness, volume, tones and so on of your morning alarm.

You can also set morning meditations, movements or inspirational pep talks to play after your alarm. These are a couple minutes long and are meant to help you get from horizontal to ambulatory. Of course, if you share a bed and the other person is still asleep, playing motivational dispatches is rude. So I get more mileage out of the sleep aids. Sound baths, ambient soundscapes, stories and guided meditations that help with the transition between the overload that is waking life and sleep.

It's $5 per month for the full library of alarm and sleep sounds and access to all the stories and music. Without it, you only get a selection. I've been subscribing for over a year now because anything that gets me up and out to a hellishly early workout in the dark is worth the cash. — *Amy Skorheim, Senior Reporter*

$170 at Amazon

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$170 at Ulta Beauty

Vertefarm

Vertefarm Hydroponic Home Garden

I'm a city boy with a not-so-green thumb. I also live in Minnesota, home of very bad winters. How do I get my daily salad fix without having to traverse that dangerous wintry mix? I use the Vertefarm Hydroponic Home Garden, which is quite literally idiot proof (I'm the idiot.) This refrigerator-sized contraption is expensive but has space for 48 grow pods and varying types of produce.

It was easy to build, relatively speaking, and works as advertised. I filled the water basin, added nutrients, inserted the seedling pods, set the light timer via an affiliated app and then waited. Lo and behold, seedlings turned to sprouts which, eventually, turned into gargantuan lettuce plants. There was really no way for me to screw it up. The only downside to this thing? Your cats will likely figure out how to pop the pods out and scatter them throughout the house. Keep the felines away until the plants are big enough to fend for themselves. — *Lawrence Bonk, Contributing Reporter*

$799 at Vertefarm

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